



Controlled precision: Valentina Shevchenko (R) catches Zhang Weili with a sharp kick during their UFC 322 title clash at Madison Square Garden. GETTY IMAGES

through well-timed takedowns that shifted the fight to the mat. Once there, Shevchenko relied on her superior strength and technique to smother Zhang with top control.

Her ability to blend Muay Thai striking with judo and grappling meant Zhang could never commit to a single discipline. By consistently winning the grappling exchanges and maintaining top position for long stretches, Shevchenko neutralised Zhang's power and cruised to a dominant unanimous decision (50-45).

Breakout performance

This was arguably the most shocking and compelling finish on the card. Carlos Prates' knockout of the former champion was built on equal parts mental warfare and pinpoint accuracy.

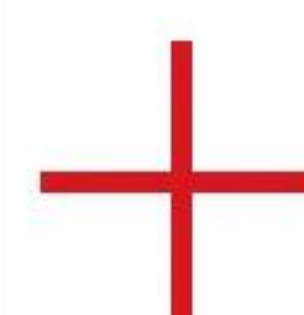
In the first round, Leon Edwards employed the right approach. He used grappling to close the distance, ignored Prates' taunts, and controlled the fight against the fence and on the

ground.

But in the second round, the Brazilian successfully lured Edwards into a striking battle by targeting his ego and forcing him to trade in the centre of the octagon.

The fight flipped in an instant when Prates' laser-targeted straight left hand found the chin of the former champion, resulting in the first knockout loss of Edwards' career. This finish highlighted Prates' elite striking power and knockout ability, marking a major statement in the welterweight division.

Meanwhile, the main card opened with a blistering knockout by Benoit Saint Denis against Beneil Dariush. The fight was decided in a split-second clinch exchange, where Saint Denis landed a clubbing left hand. The win was a statement of his heavy striking, proving he can end a fight against a top lightweight contender instantly and establishing him as a genuine threat in the 155-pound division.



Did you know?

Makhachev, with the welterweight title win, became the 11th fighter in the UFC to hold belts in multiple weight classes. He is tied with the legendary Anderson Silva for the longest winning streak in UFC history with 16 consecutive victories. His professional MMA record now stands at 28 wins and just 1 loss, a dominant win percentage of 94.4 per cent. Conor McGregor was the first to achieve this feat when he defeated Jose Aldo to win the featherweight belt.

Amanda Nunes later became the first female fighter to win and hold championship belts in two different weight classes simultaneously (women's bantamweight and women's featherweight).